

MINDTREK

Mindtrek 2026, Tampere, 6th of October, 2026

Sovereign *by habit*

20 years of self-hosting from source
on European servers

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A strategy topic, *told from the server room*

Europe is planning its way towards digital sovereignty.
This talk is about what it looks like in daily work.

The layers *we stopped looking inside*

Containers

Package an application with everything it needs, so it runs the same everywhere.

Orchestration

Schedule and scale those containers across many machines.

Managed platforms

Someone else runs the servers, the database and the updates.

Headless and SaaS

The content, the forms or the search live in another company's service.

Where the habit *comes from*

[1998: the first machine and filesystem I could touch.]
About twenty years of Linux servers I can log into.

2013: *a company on the same habit*

- Dude starts out on partners' hosting.
- Without root access, every change means waiting for someone else.
- [Year]: the first servers of our own.
- Since then, all of our infrastructure runs on European servers.



Choosing providers, *and leaving them*

- [Year] Partners' shared hosting
- [Year] The first VPS
- [Year] A French provider
- [Year] A Finnish datacentre
- [Year] The outage
- Today: a mix of European providers



The fleet *today*

[N] servers

[What each class of server runs.]

Our own services

Plausible for analytics, Outline for docs, Twenty for the CRM.

15 people

A web agency, no separate operations team.

Mastodon

mementomori.social, about 1000 users, since 2022.

From *upstream*

Built from source

[Which software is compiled by hand.]

Configured by hand

Every configuration file is written and read by us, with our own defaults.

Upstream packages

[Which software comes from the distribution or upstream packages.]

Why the line is there

[Why some things are built and others are packaged.]

Working *on the server*

Find it

```
ssh web-01  
less /etc/nginx/sites-enabled/example.conf  
journalctl -u nginx --since '10 min ago'
```

Fix it

```
sudo vim /etc/nginx/sites-enabled/example.conf  
sudo nginx -t  
sudo systemctl reload nginx
```

Log in, read the configuration, change the thing, test it and reload. Every step is visible, and every step can be undone.

Automation, *and what stays manual*

Automated

[Ansible playbooks, backups, monitoring, updates.]

By hand

[What we keep manual on purpose.]

Coming round to it

[How Ansible entered the picture.]

The line between

[How we decide which side something goes on.]

Where it *costs more*

- Onboarding takes longer when every layer is yours.
- Rebuilding a server exactly the same way needs discipline.
- Knowledge collects in one person unless it is written down.
- [Hours of maintenance per month, counted honestly.]

Where it *pays*

- Every layer is understood, so nothing is a black box.
- Problems can be read from logs and configuration files.
- Moving to another provider is work, but it is possible.
- [The debugging story where reading the layer solved it.]

Where it *still leaks*

DNS

[Who runs our DNS, and what happens if they go away.]

Email

Deliverability depends on the large mail providers.

CDN

[Where static files and caching depend on another company.]

AI APIs

The models we use run on servers we do not control.

Knowing every layer *is practical sovereignty*

Host one thing yourself, end to end,
and keep it running for a year.



Kiitos. *Questions?*

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